‘Preparing for the group discussion,’ chipped in Prabhdeep, one of our fellow candidates sitting in front of us. ‘We’re brushing up on our GK and current affairs.’

‘So we go for the GD after the breakfast?’ I asked.

Prabhdeep nodded. ‘Here, take a look if you want to.’ She offered her current affairs notes to me. Reluctantly, I took them.

I wasn’t really sure I’d even give them a read. General knowledge was a grey area and the notes only scared me more. Hema could see the discomfort I felt when talking about it.

‘Well, it isn’t necessary to be Derek O’Brien when you appear for the GD,’ Hema said as she took the notes from me and gave them back to Prabhdeep.

‘Thanks anyway, Prabhdeep,’ I said with a forced smile. Prabhdeep smiled back and continued to read her notes. The thought of appearing for the GD without any preparation vanquished my hunger. I put the toast back on my plate and walked out of the mess.

‘Wait for me,’ Hema followed me to the veranda outside in a run, caught her breath and continued, ‘we don’t have to worry about the GD. We’ll do just fine.’ I turned to face her and smiled.

‘I don’t even read the newspaper. I just don’t know what’s happening in the world. Bollywood, yes, that’s something you can ask me about,’ I said as we strolled, trying to de-stress together.

‘Who reads newspapers? Ugh . . . there are better things to do. And about the GD, we’ll cross that bridge when we get to it,’ Hema said as we circled the veranda. We chatted for a while until we were made to assemble for the exam near the football field.

It was half past ten on a sunny morning. The seating was arranged in groups of twelve chairs placed in a semicircle in front of the instructors’ tables inside a vast training shed. A pair of ropes hung from pillars in one corner of the shed and a gymnast’s horse rested in another. A few dumb-bells were stacked neatly near the ropes. Physical training facilities could be found in every defence establishment. Nine groups had been formed, with roughly twelve candidates in each group. Unfortunately, or otherwise, three